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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PRESIDENT APPOINTS SIX SC JUSTICES

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20

President Ramchandra Paudel has appointed six Justices to the Supreme Court on the recommendation of the Judicial Council. President Paudel appointed them on Wednesday as per Article 129 of the constitution. Four of those appointed are judges of different High Court and two are senior advocates.

According to Shailaja Regmi, the spokesperson for the Office of the President, those appointed six Justices are Saranga Subedi, a judge of the High Court Janakpur, Abdul Ajij Musalman, a judge of the High Court Hetauda, Mahesh Sharma Paudel, a judge of the High Court Patan, Tekh Prasad Dhungana, judge of High Court Patan, and senior advocates Sunil Kumar Pokharel and Bal Krishna Dhakal.

Earlier today, a meeting of the Parliamentary Hearing Committee endorsed the names of the six persons recommended by the Judicial Council for the appointment. Chaired by Committee senior-most member Pashupati Shumsher Rana, the meeting approved the nominations of all six persons.

The Committee had conducted parliamentary hearings on the recommendations on December 15, 17 and 18.

SRI LANKAN FOREIGN MINISTER SABRY ARRIVES IN KATHMANDU

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 20

Sri Lankan Foreign Minister Mum Ali Sabry has arrived in Kathmandu on a four-day visit on Wednesday.

The Sri Lankan Minister arrived here to attend the first meeting of Nepal-Sri Lanka Joint Commission. He was received by Foreign Secretary Sewa Lamsal at Tribhuvan International Airport, according to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs.



The Joint Commission meeting is being held on December 21 to 22. The meeting will have participation of officials from various ministries from Nepal, while the Nepali delegation will be led by Foreign Minister NP Saud. The foreign ministers will also hold a bilateral meeting. Sri Lankan Minister is scheduled to pay courtesy call on President Ram Chandra Paudel and Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal.



PHOTO: RSS

Mt. Sisne in Rukum (East) has turned almost to a mound of black rock due to lack of timely snowfall and melting of existing snows over it. Scientists have pointed out that this is the result of global warming.

Sugarcane's min support price fixed at Rs. 635 per quintal

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20

The government has fixed the minimum support price of sugarcane at Rs. 635 per quintal for the current fiscal year 2023/24.

A meeting of the Council of Ministers held in Singha Durbar on Wednesday afternoon approved the minimum farm-gate price of the sugarcane tabled by the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development, Minister for Communication of Information Technology Rekha Sharma informed after the Cabinet meeting.

Minister Sharma said that the government's one-year performance was reviewed in the Cabinet meeting. "There was a general review of the government formed about a year ago," Minister Sharma said.

According to her, the regular meeting of the Council of Ministers will be held again on Thursday.

The government fixed the minimum retail price of sugarcane based on the cost of production, transportation, profit and the subsidy provided by the government to the sugarcane farmers.

The price includes the government's subsidy of Rs. 70 per quintal to the sugarcane farmers. The sugar factories will pay the farmers Rs. 565 per quintal.

The Ministry had held several rounds of meetings with the farmers and the sugar factories to determine the support price of sugarcane for this year.

» CABINET DECISIONS



Minister Rekha Sharma

According to the Spokesperson for the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development Ministry, Sabnam Shivakoti Aryal, on Tuesday only, the ministry recommended the minimum support price of sugar analysing the cost of production, transportation cost and other variables to be endorsed by the Cabinet.

The support price has increased by Rs. 25 per quintal this year, Aryal said.

Aryal said that the Ministry had fixed the minimum support price scientifically by analysing the cost of production, transportation and profit.

The government had fixed the support price of sugarcane at Rs. 610 per quintal, including Rs. 70 per quintal subsidy for the farmers last fiscal year.

Meanwhile, according to our Sarlahi Correspondent, the President of Nepal Sugarcane Producers' Association, Kapil Muni Mainali has expressed his dissatisfaction over the minimum sugarcane price fixed by the government.

He complained that in the discussion held between the government, industrialists and farmers' representatives at the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development on December 3, it was decided to hold a tripartite meeting to fix the price, but today, the government set the price in collusion with the owners of the sugar industries.

He said the government did not listen to them when they asked for further discussion for fixing the price of sugarcane addressing the demand of farmers.

The sugar factories have already started crushing sugarcane before the government fixed the minimum price.

The sugarcane farmers of Sarlahi district are agitating demanding that the price of sugarcane be fixed at Rs. 750 per quintal this year and that the subsidy amount of Rs. 70 given by the government for the sugarcane sold a year ago should be paid as soon as possible.

Next action plan will be based on past performance: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has expressed his intent to seriously assess his one-year tenure and devise the forthcoming action plan.

He said so while addressing a meeting convened for the joint annual review of the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development and the Ministry of Land Management, Cooperatives and Poverty Alleviation at Singha Durbar on Wednesday afternoon.

During the meeting, the Prime Minister said, "Today's meeting was called to gather detailed information about the overall status of the two ministries. This, in itself, holds significant importance."

"It has been one year since I took leadership of the government. I intend to create a calendar and engage in discussions with all ministries. I will formulate plans after analysing our accomplishments and identifying challenges encountered," he said.

» MINISTERIAL REVIEW MEET

The Prime Minister asserted that he would arrive at the office at 10 am every morning and actively participate in regular discussions, reviews, and evaluations. "Our utmost priority is serving the people. Strengthening our service delivery builds public trust towards the state. Our focus should centre around keeping people at the forefront," he said.

Stating that agriculture and land are the main harmony of the country's economy, politics, and society, he said that without elevating agriculture as the foundation of development and implementing scientific land management, achieving prosperity would be unattainable.

"Hydropower and industry also hold significance, yet the industry's operation relies on agriculture. Therefore, the emphasis should be on elevating agricultural productivity and implementing scientific land management," he further elaborated. He reiterated his commitment to adopting a novel approach while formulating the next budget, emphasising the overhaul of the conventional structure of policy, programmes and budgets.

During the meeting, Minister for Agriculture and Livestock Development Dr. Beduram Bhusal stressed the need to establish key priorities for the agricultural sector.

Likewise, Minister of Land Management, Cooperatives, and Poverty Alleviation, Ranjita Shrestha Chaudhary, highlighted the government's concerted efforts to tackle issues concerning landless squatters, unorganised residents and bonded labourers like Haruwa and Charuwa.

» SEE PAGE 6

CIAA asks govt for steps to control irregularities

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20



The Commission for Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA) has given suggestions to the government based on the interaction held on November 22 and 23 with government regulatory agencies and public corporations.

The suggestions include the points regarding implementation of development projects, tender bidding process, preparation of environment impact assessment (EIA) report, purchase of vehicles and other logistics and reports to be submitted by project consultants.

The commission has suggested legal action against irregularities and rule violations in the functioning of government machineries.

Other suggestions of CIAA include timely auditing, effective service delivery, updating of employee records, appointment of efficient manpower on the basis of necessities, effective monitoring of work performance and formulation of strategic plan on regulation of public corporations.

» SEE PAGE 6

EC approves voter list for Jan 25 NA election

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20

The EC announced the approval of a voter's list for the election of the Upper House, comprising 2,047 voters.

The Election Commission has endorsed the voter list for the election of the National Assembly (NA) slated for January 25.

Issuing a press statement on Wednesday, the EC announced the approval of a voter's list for the election of the Upper House, comprising 2,047 voters, including 549 Provincial Assembly members and 1,498 local levels' chiefs and deputy chiefs.

Election Commission's Secretary and Spokesperson, Shaligram Sharma Paudel said that of 550 members of the Provincial Assemblies, one had passed away so the EC has fixed the number at 549.

Meanwhile, there are 1,498 voters in local governments, including the chairs, vice-chairs of the rural municipalities and the mayors and deputy-mayors of the municipalities.

Among the total of 1,506 local representatives, the names of eight individuals were removed from the list, said Paudel. Names of one rural chair, one vice chair and one deputy mayor are not on the voter list as they have already passed away, he said.

Similarly, the names of one rural municipality chair and four mayors have been excluded from the list as they are currently suspended from the posts, said Paudel.

As a result, an approved list of 1,498 voters has been fixed in local governments, he added. As per the election schedule, the voter list will be published at the Election Officer's Office on January 5, 2024, and the final voter list will be published in January 7.

The total weightage of the vote of provincial assembly members is 29,097, and 28,462 of the local representatives. The total weightage of votes for the National Assembly election is 57,559.

The EC has fixed the voting weightage of a provincial member at 53 and while that of a local people's representative 19.

'No sign of JN.1 variant of coronavirus in Nepal'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20

The World Health Organisation (WHO) on Tuesday informed about the new JN.1 variant of coronavirus strain, classifying it as a 'variant of interest'.

The WHO said that the new variant had a low risk to public health, and the current vaccine would still be effective and protect against severe disease and death from the JN. 1 variant of COVID-19.

Experts have said that the COVID-19 virus still poses a threat because of its ever-changing variants and easy transmission capability. According to Dr. Sher Bahadur Pun, Chief of the Clinical Research Unit at the Sukraraj Tropical and Infectious Disease Hospital, there is not yet any evidence about the finding of the new variant in Nepal.

But since the new variant is seen active in India, and since we have an open border with India, the new variant is likely to enter Nepal sooner than later because of the free movements of people, he said. "Therefore, the responsible authorities should be serious about this."

The surge in the cases of a new variant of JN.1 in India has caused concern in Nepal. The new variant was first found in Kerala State of India which later spread to Maharashtra and Goa.



According to the Times of India, the active cases of COVID-19 in India have reached 1,970 from 938 in nine days.

The rise of the COVID-19 virus and its new variants around the glove has been the concern of all.

"The health effects of COVID-19 and its variants vary according to individuals. Some cause minor symptoms and others are life-threatening. The virus has been undergoing mutations, therefore, people should take precautions. Communicable diseases can pass on easily where there are a lot of movements of people. If the new variant is found, then the authorities should inform people about this as soon as possible," said Pun.

Pun also stressed the importance of the COVID-19 vaccine and its booster doses. "Boosters have shown a good response to the virus, but it is not yet clear how many times one has to receive the jab. There should be a clear message about the boosters and their availability," Dr. Pun added.

COVID-19 virus mutation is not a new phenomenon. Over the years it has undergone several mutations. Only the usage of vaccines and herd immunity have helped fight the virus.

"We will see the outcome of the new variant soon in India, and its impact on people. Only after that, we will know whether the variant is more dangerous than the previous ones. Till then, the authorities should increase their surveillance and the general public should take precautions while going to crowded places," Dr. Pun said.

Coronavirus disease 2019 (COVID-19) was first identified in Wuhan, China, in December 2019. By now it killed almost seven million people around the world with 12,031 reported deaths in Nepal.

Reopening Udayapur Cement Factory possible only thru collective efforts: Dr. Mahat

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat said that the reopening of the Udayapur Cement Factory could be possible only through the collective efforts of the concerned stakeholders.

While inspecting the mines used by the industry on Wednesday, he said that the subsidy of the government could not be the solution to the sick industries, informed the Ministry of Finance in a statement.

The management of such establishments should be improved, and the workers should understand their responsibility, said Dr. Mahat, adding that evaluation and assessment should be conducted to find out who did not fulfil their responsibilities and the situation that led to the deterioration of the industry. "Many industries operate in the private sector.



PHOTO: TRN

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat observing Udayapur Cement Industry on Wednesday.

There are more than five dozen private sector cement industries. The workers complained that they were facing indifferences from the management and the government," said FM Dr. Mahat, "Private sector buys land, builds industries, buys machines with loans and operates them, and earns profits even after paying all operating expenses."

The Udayapur Cement Factory was established with the support of Rs. 440 million from the Japanese government.

The government has invested Rs. 1 billion. However the company has failed to manage the operating expenses despite a good demand for its products. It has a liability of Rs. 750 million.

According to Dr. Mahat, the current condition of the industry is the cumulative result of the government appointing managers who have poor knowledge of the industry, lack professionalism, and workers' poor performance.

Stating that the crisis was not the result of the COVID-19 pandemic and it began much before than that, the Finance Minister said that no one can escape from their responsibilities. "We did not have the mindset that we should protect the public property by giving it more importance.

This is why the public sector has not been successful in Nepal," he said.

He maintained that although the participation of the government in the industry was not necessary, it invested in the sector to make the private sector competitive and discourage monopoly.

"It is our responsibility to save this industry. After saving it, we can demand more facilities. We must not forget that facilities could be obtained if the industry remains operational, else there will be nowhere to go," he said.

FM Dr. Mahat said that if there was no commitment from the management and trade union, it would be difficult to save the industry. If there is a commitment to save the industry, a lot can be done by using new technology over time, he maintained.

NAC'S PROFITS INCREASE BY 144 PER CENT

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20

The national flag carrier Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC) claims to have increased its income by 144 per cent in three fiscal years.

Issuing a press release on Tuesday, the Corporation said that it had earned Rs. 22.24 billion in the last fiscal year 2022/23.

In the fiscal year 2020/21, its income was Rs. 9.10 billion.

However, it did not give any information if its spending also increased during this period or not.

The statement also stays silent about the Corporation's profits.

The NAC currently has six planes in operation.

Four of them fly international routes while two fly to domestic destinations.

Fish-keeping growing in the vicinity of forest

RSS
Triveni (Nawalparasi), Dec. 20

Local residents of buffer zone in Nawalpur (Bardaghat-Susta East) have long been facing trouble with the rise in the incidents of wildlife rampage.

Wildlife's frequent intrusion to the paddy farms caused loss and damage to the farmers in buffer zone.

In a bid to avoid wildlife menace in Chitwan National Park's buffer zone, some local farmers switched over their profession from paddy-farming to fish-keeping.

Devraj Subba, a farmer of Kawaswoti municiplaity-7, said they have shifted their profession to fish-keeping to avoid wildlife intrusion and earn up more income.

He further said almost every household has possessed fish ponds in the area along the forest border.

He said that most of the people living along the border area of the forest have fish ponds. "Around 70 families here have ponds.

With the rise in wildlife rampage, plantation of other crops in the area adjacent to the forest cannot be saved," he said, adding fish-keeping has turned to be an effective option to the paddy-farming as its income is also good.

Yam Bahadur Nepali, who had been cultivating paddy earlier, has also constructed fish pond later. He said the trend of constructing fish ponds has increased as a livelihood option.

Lately number of fish farmers is increasing in Devchuli, Kawaswoti and Madhyabindu municipalities of the district. The community forests here have also been supporting the construction of fish ponds in the bordering areas of the forest.

Chairperson of the forest, Khil Bahadur Gurung said that the Model Buffer Zone Community Forest Users' Group has been providing support to those who want to keep fish. There are a total of 140 fish ponds in the areas which fall under the Model Buffer Zone Community Forest and Krishnasar Buffer Zone Community Forest.

Chair Gurung further commented that fish-keeping has also helped mitigate human-wildlife conflict in the area. Fish-keeping profession nearby forest area is expanding of late, he shared.

He said it has also resolved the problem of wildlife ruining crops on the one hand and on the other fish farming business has generated a decent income.

Kawasoti Municipality has been providing grants by declaring the wards as pocket areas as the residents of the buffer zones have been attracted to fish farming. Chief of Agriculture Development Section of Kawasoti Municipality, Shiva Narayan Kumal, said that ward no. 7 and 13 of Kawasoti municipality are being developed as fish pocket areas.

"We have started providing necessary subsidies from the municipality as the fish farming area is increasing in the vicinity of the forest and the farmers are also earning good income," he said.

METAL INDUSTRIES IN TAKSAR SHRINKING

RSS
Taksar (Bhojpur), Dec. 20

The metal industries in historical marketplace in Bhojpur district-Taksar are on the verge of extinction in lack of skilled human resources and availability of raw materials. Only two or three families, mostly from Newar communities, in the locality are currently pursuing the processing and production of metal products.

The industries that once minted coins and manufactured millions worth of products annually have shrunken to the extent that Buddharaj Shakya and a couple of families are making metal materials upon the demand at present.

Another local involved in metal business Bimal Kumar Shakya spoke of the need to re-motivate the local metal merchants involved in production and sale of the metal materials to keep alive the metal industries in the ancient marketplace as well as to preserve artworks made up of various metals.

The artisans that were known to make artistic utensils and tools such as Khukuris made from brass, copper and iron have opted for other professions due to the sustainability concern from the profession the scope of which was narrowing worryingly lately.

Sanukaji Shakya voiced his concern that it was increasingly becoming difficult to save metal business in Taksar due to the increasing migration rate of artisans to elsewhere and departure from their traditional occupation to other lucrative business and jobs.

Korea pledges USD 300,000 to help quake victims

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20

The Government of the Republic of Korea has pledged to provide aid of $300,000 to support earthquake relief efforts in Nepal.

Earlier, the earthquake that struck Jajarkot in Nepal on November 3 had claimed 157 lives affecting 300,000 people in Karnali Province, including the districts of Jajarkot and Rukum West

Issuing a press statement on Wednesday, the United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA), informed about the fund and said that it would be channelled through the UNFPA to Nepal.

It said that with the support from the Republic of Korea, UNFPA would continue to distribute essential health supplies including 5,000 winter kits, 2,000 dignity kits and 14 sets of different health kits that would serve over 40,000 women and girls over the next three months.

According to the statement, Taeyoung Park, Ambassador of the Republic of Korea to Nepal said, "The Government of the Republic of Korea is committed to providing assistance to the most vulnerable people affected by the earthquake in Jajarkot, in collaboration with UNFPA.

This commitment aligns with Korea's longstanding partnership with Nepal, which will mark the 50th anniversary of diplomatic relations between the two nations in 2024. Korea has been providing immediate support to Nepal during challenging times, including the 2015 Nepal Earthquake and the COVID-19 pandemic.

The people and the Government of Korea stand with Nepal, hoping that this assistance will contribute to the recovery of the areas affected by the recent earthquake." Similarly, Won Young Hong, UNFPA Representative, said that the Republic of Korea was committed to humanitarian causes.

She said, "We are profoundly grateful to the Government of the Republic of Korea for their invaluable support.

This contribution has enabled the UNFPA to deliver humanitarian supplies to the affected women and girls, ensuring that their fundamental needs for basic sanitation, menstrual hygiene, and sexual and reproductive health are met.

Such acts of generosity and compassion resonate with the core principles of solidarity and humanity, reflecting the Republic of Korea's leadership in addressing global challenges."

NFTA suggests adopting multi-rate on VAT



PHOTO: TRN

NFTA members holding discussion on suggestions regarding tax to the High-Level Tax System Reform Suggestion Committee.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20

Nepal Foreign Trade Association (NFTA) has submitted its suggestions regarding tax to the High-Level Tax System Reform Suggestion Committee.

President of NFTA Binod Kumar Sethia presented the suggestions prepared by the Association at a programme held at the office of the Inland Revenue Department on Wednesday.

While presenting the suggestions, President Sethia pointed out the need for facilitating the business rather than regulating it.

He said that if the government created a comfortable environment for business, the private sector would increase investment and businesses, the businessmen would get profit, the government would get revenue and common people would get employment opportunities.

"But the government has emphasised regulation rather than facilitation," said Sethia, "The businessmen are suffering because of this, the government has not been able to collect targeted revenue and the country has not been able to progress."

Even if the policy is good, achievement will not be gained, he said adding, "If the intention is not good, no matter how good the policy is, it will not yield the desired results."

The Association has pointed out the need to implement the concept of multi-rate on value-added tax (VAT), reduce the slabs of income tax, and pay attention to whether it encourages tax evasion or not while determining the rate of tax and duties.

As the high rate of tax is encouraging illegal trade in the country due to open borders, businessmen who are doing business following the law are suffering and the government is losing revenue, said the Association.

President Sethia emphasised that there should be a strategy to control the illegal trade. The Association has presented the suggestions that the concept of multi-rate should be applied in value addition.

He said that Nepal's policies and laws are an obstacle in terms of benefiting Indian tourists and developing Nepal as a destination for shopping, marriage programmes and gatherings.

Even though the government is talking about bringing in foreign investment, our policy rules discourage it, it said.

The Association claimed that businessmen were suffering from the practice of mistrust among government agencies.

President Sethia that it was unfair for the government to charge a fine for a day's delay to the businessmen or the general public without paying the amount that remains as dues with government for a long time.

"Just as the general public fulfil their duties, the government, government agencies and civil servants should also fulfil their responsibilities," he said.

On the occasion, the chairman of the High Level Tax System Reform Suggestion Committee, Bidyadhar Mallik, said that the committee would make suggestions to the government after studying the policies, rules and laws in detail regarding tax.

Members of the Committee Prof. Dr. Ram Prasad Gyawali and Laxman Aryal and officials of the Internal Revenue Department and Ministry of Finance were present in the programme. Similarly, executive members of the Nepal Foreign Trade Association were also present in the meeting.



Elephants prolong stay, cause more damages in Jhapa

BY BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL
Damak, Dec. 20

People in Jhapa and Morang districts in Koshi Province have been unable to sleep at night as the wild elephants, which have entered Nepal from India, have prolonged their stay in local forests. Herds of elephants are noticed almost every day not only in Jhapa but also in Morang and Sunsari districts.

In the past, the elephants used to come to Nepal from India, stay here for a while and return to India. But this time, they are found prolonging their stay. They have been living in various forests across eastern Nepal, such as the Jalthal forest in Jhapa, Charaali forest and the Humsedumse community forest in Damak. The forests of Jhapa, in particular, have become a haven for them.

According to Meghraj Rai, the head of the Division Forest Office in Jhapa, the recurrent problem of wild elephants is due to insufficient attention during the formulation of policies and programmes. He said that the problem was escalating every year. He suggested implementing agricultural programmes in the areas affected by elephants.

The primary reason for elephants migrating to and residing in Nepal is attributed to their search for food.

"Despite Jhapa being an elephant-affected district, it continues to produce corn by designating it as a corn zone. Elephants are fond of maize corn, and they come and stay here to enjoy the corn," Rai said.



PHOTO: BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL/TRN

Wild elephants seen in the jungle.

According to Rai, even though there are no thick forests in Jhapa, elephants frequent the district and the availability of corn, a preferred food source for them, is what motivates the elephants to come here, he added.

"They arrive in Nepal due to a scarcity of food in India, and upon finding a year-round food supply in Nepal, they choose to stay here. In the regions affected by elephants in India, tea and pepper are grown commercially, which are not consumed by elephants," Rai informed.

The issue began to surface due to insufficient attention to the construction of elephant-friendly structures. The importance of promoting coexistence between humans and elephants through the development of structures that are considerate of elephants. "We are planning essential consultations and programmes with relevant authorities to address this issue," he added.

Jeevan Pathak, a Forester at the Division Forest Office, said that Jhapa could barely provide enough food to sustain four to five elephants.

Their recent efforts have been focused on planting more vegetation in the forest. The elephants venture out when they do not find sufficient food in the forest, leading to the current situation, he said.

Acting Chief of the Agricultural Knowledge Centre in Jhapa, Sagar Bista said that the elephants have been causing great damage to rice and corn yearly. He said it was not practical and scientific to reduce their cultivation when Jhapa is known only for rice and maize. Elephants can be lured by planting fruits in the forest, but it is not practical to reduce rice and corn cultivation in the area, said Bista.

Shankar C Luitel, a specialist in human-elephant conflict management, said that the elephants are lingering in the area due to their preference for the taste of potatoes and sugarcane. They have started living in the forest during the day and enter the human settlements and farms at night.

Meanwhile, an old man died in an elephant attack in Jhapa on Wednesday. According to District Police Office Jhapa, Pathal Rajbansi, 60, of Haldibari Rural Municipality, died in the attack.

The search for Pathal began after he went missing on Wednesday morning. Shukh Lal Rajbansi, Chairman of Ward No. 2 of the rural municipality, said that Pathal, employed as an Office Assistant in the rural municipality, did not come to the office. Concerned about his whereabouts, Rajbansi, along with the police, initiated a search. The police were alerted by locals upon discovering Pathal's body in Haldibari forest.

Police reported that Pathal, who left his house in the morning, was discovered dead in the jungle near his residence. Locals said that elephants have been sighted in the Haldibari forest over the past few days. Pathal was the sixth person killed by elephants in Jhapa in the last five months.

NEWS BRIEF

Man crushed by thresher machine

Damak: A man died after being pulled by a thresher machine while working in a paddy field on Wednesday morning. The deceased has been identified as Nunuwa Tudu, 57, of Jhapa Rural Municipality-2 of the district.

According to the District Police Office, Jhapa, Duduwa was crushed by the machine while harvesting the paddy and collecting hay. Tractor operator Chandra Dev Rajbanshi has been at large after the incident.

Two Indians held with four quintals of marijuana

Chitwan: The District Police Office, Chitwan, has arrested two Indian nationals with 396-kg marijuana.

The arrestees have been identified as Anil Giri, 45, of Baijai Thana Sambal district of Uttar Pradesh, India and Rajpal Singh, 37, of Kailadevi Thana Apawati Kutawapur village.

The Nepal Police made them public on Tuesday evening. Spokesperson for the District Police Office, DSP Bijaya Raj Pandit shared that the Indian nationals were arrested with marijuana from Bharatpur Metropolitan City-1, Anptari.

The police confiscated the banned substance while being smuggled to Narayangadh from Mugling in a truck with Indian number plate (JH 02 W 9631). The police recovered 28 packets of marijuana from the cabin of the truck.

A police team headed by SP Rameshwor Karki caught them. According to the police sources, an investigation into the case is underway.

(TRN)

'Autism is not a disease but a problem'

RSS
Chitwan, Dec. 20

The Bagmati Province alone has a total of 1,253 people suffering from autism. Among them, 495 are in Kathmandu, 113 in Chitwan, 83 in Lalitpur, 78 in Bhaktapur and 77 in Makawanpur.

Likewise, 75 people are suffering from autism in Kavre, 70 in Dhading, 65 each in Nuwakot and Sindhuli 54 in Sindhupalchowk, 33 in Dolakha and 17 in Rasuwa.

As per the information shared at a workshop on autism organized by the Bagmati Province Health Ministry, currently 4,886 people now are suffering from autism in Nepal.

According to the Health Ministry's expert doctor Shakar Khanal, it is estimated that around 300,000 people, including one in 100 people, have this problem based on the data of the World Health Organization. He said that four men equal to one woman have this problem.

According to him, 328 people in the mountains, 2,229 in the hills and 2,329 in the Terai have this problem according to the geographical condition.

It was informed that the problem of autism is increasing in urban areas rather than in rural areas. As per the data provided, 1,728 people are living with the problem in villages and 3,158 people in the urban areas.

According to Surendra Bajracharya of the Autism Care Nepal Society, autism is not a disease but a problem. "Though autism is detected at the age of six months in different countries, it is found only after 18 months in Nepal", he said. Sharing that around 0.8 percent population with disabilities are also having autism in Nepal, he said autism is a genetic condition and caused by genetics, environment and infection.

So far there is no treatment of the problem, he said, adding it can be improved with various types of therapy and rehabilitation measures.

On the occasion, Bagmati Province Health Secretary Deepak Tiwari said that the province government has made efforts for the first time to solve the problems seen in the issue of autism.

He said such programmes would facilitate the government's future works and collection of actual data. Representatives from the health institutions within the province and various organisations working in the field of autism participated in the programme.

Landless people in Gaurishankar provided ownership certificates

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Charikot, Dec. 20

Gaurishankar Rural Municipality in Dolakha has presented certificates to the landless squatters before distributing them land ownership certificates.

The National Land Commission District Committee, Dolakha, has distributed the certificates so that all those landless people of the rural municipality possessing the certificates will be eligible to get the land ownership certificates. The committee informed that the certificates have been distributed to the landless squatters in Ward Nos. 3, 6, 7 and 8.

The certificates were provided to 47 landless families in the presence of Bishwas Karki, Chairman of Gaurishankar Rural Municipality, Lalit Bahadur Magar, Chairman of National Land Commission District Committee, Dolakha, and Shrijana Katuwal, Chief of Survey Officer, according to the Rural Municipality.

Among the nine local levels in the district, 27 certificates were distributed in Bhimeshwor Municipality and 47 in Gaurshankar Rural Municipality, said Magar, the chairman of the National Land Commission District Committee, Dolakha.

He said that they had the plan to distribute the certificates to the beneficiaries, who had earlier failed to fill up the forms including the required documents and three-generation details, after completing the process.

Chairman Karki said that the distribution of the certificate has paved the way for the landless squatters to get the land ownership certificates. "The certificate which we have provided now will make it easier for the landless people to get the land ownership certificate," Karki said.

He further said that all Nepalis have the right to have land, and the process to give the land ownership certificates to the landless people has been initiated. The landless squatters of Gaurishankar Rural Municipality were happy after they were presented with the certificates.

The Land Commission District Committee Dolakha has also completed the work of collecting data on the landless people in the remaining seven local levels.

Only 20 per cent works completed in Koshi Hospital in 30 months



PHOTO: TRN

The under construction building of Koshi Hospital.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Biratnagar, Dec. 20

The delay in infrastructure construction of Koshi Hospital in Biratnagar has affected its service delivery. The government had, 30 months ago, provided a budget for the construction of a five-storey building, but the construction company has not completed the work yet.

The Department of Urban Development and Building Construction, Biratnagar, granted the construction contract to the Raman-Bhumi, B.I.P.L JV to complete the building construction works within 30 months by July 7, 2021.

The company which received the contract claiming 40 per cent less than the demanded budget of Rs. 500 million have completed only 20 per cent of building construction work and the deadline for completing the project is going to end on January 7, 2024. The company contracted the work at Rs. 332.24 million.

The locals are not getting timely treatment due to the lack of infrastructure. Daily 2,000 patients from the financially disadvantaged groups, those included in health insurance programmes and those from the middle class are not getting emergency and regular treatment due to the delay in building infrastructure.

The two-storey building was demolished to build a new building. Therefore, services including X-rays and ultrasounds are not being conducted properly. The misunderstanding between the contractor partners is said to be the reason for the delay.

The owner of Bhumi Construction, Krishna Bohara, has been out of contact leaving the work in the middle and only the owner of Raman Construction Company, Pawan Kumar Mahat, has been continuing the work. "The department is preparing to extend the deadline for project completion. We have warned them of actions if the construction work is not completed within the new deadline," said Surendra Kumar Shah, Head of the Department of Urban Development and Building Construction, Biratnagar.

The construction company has already spent Rs. 80 million while completing only 20 per cent of the work. The 350-bed Koshi Hospital is planning to increase its beds to 500, once the construction work is completed.

MINITRUCK KNOCKS MAN TO DEATH

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sarlahi, Dec. 20

A person was killed when a minitruck hit a man in Lalbandi-1 of Sarlahi district along the Nawalpur-Malangawa road section.

In the accident, Rudal Kumar Danuwar, 50, of Haripur Municipality-7 of the district died. During the accident, Danuwar was cycling towards his home. According to the police, he was hit by the minitruck with registration Prov. 2-04-001 Ka 0014.

Deceased Danuwar was identified as a labourer working in a local brick kiln in Dabari. He was pronounced dead by the doctor when taken to the provincial hospital, Malangawa. Police have impounded the truck.

Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC)
Kantipath, Kathmandu, Nepal

**TENDER NOTICE
FOR
AUCTION SALE OF TWO MA-60 & THREE Y-12 E AIRCRAFT
ON
"AS IS WHERE IS BASIS"**

Date of Publication : 21 December, 2023
Last date of Submission : 4 February, 2024

Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC) invites all interested companies and individuals to submit their sealed tender document for the Auction Sale of Two MA-60 & Three Y-12 E Aircraft on "as is where is basis". The sealed tender document must reach at Corporate Department, Nepal Airlines Corporation, Kantipath, Kathmandu, Nepal within 04 February 2024 (13:00 hrs Nepalese standard time). The sealed tender document received after last date and time of submission shall not be accepted. For more details, please visit NAC's website:
http://www.nepalairlines.com.np/home/notices
NAC reserves all rights to accept or reject all or any tender document received without giving any reason whatsoever.

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Physical Infrastructure and Transport
Department of Roads
Mechanical Training Center, Patandhoka
Notice of LOI (Publication Date: 21 December 2023)

This is to inform to all concerned bidders who had submitted their bids, invited under tender notice IFB Number mentioned below published on 19 October 2023 in "The Rising Nepal", that the "Letter of Intent" has been issued in favor of following bidders having substantially responsive and lowest evaluated bid price.

Sr. No.	Contract Identification No. and Detail	Bidder's Name & Address	Bid Price (Including VAT)
1	MTC/33701014/NCB/080-81/01 *(*Supply and Delivery of Training Simulator: Backhoe Loader – *1 Unit)*	M/S Panchakanya Automobiles, Kathmandu, Nepal	Nrs.39,96,000.00
2	MTC/33701014/NCB/080-81/02 *(*Supply and Delivery of Light Vehicle Diesel Engine Training Bench – *1 Unit)*	M/S Panchakanya Automobiles, Kathmandu, Nepal	Nrs.29,96,000.00
3	MTC/33701014/NCB/080-81/03 *(*Supply and Delivery of Universal Vehicle Scanner – *5 Units)*	M/S Worldwide Trading Pvt. Ltd., Kathmandu, Nepal	Nrs.20,34,000.00

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Perfection is not attainable, but if we chase perfection we can catch excellence.
-- Vince Lombardi

EDITORIAL

Cooling Amid Warming

In his address to the 28th Conference of Parties on Climate Change (COP28) Dubai early this month, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda had successfully drawn the attention of the international community to the devastating impact of climate change on Himalayas. In his opening lines, he had struck the right chord: mountains are tortured by rising temperatures. The PM's remark has been substantiated by a number of scientific research. A recent Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) report states that the climate-induced disasters are breaking records in the Himalayas. One-third of our glaciers have disappeared and another one-third is feared to be lost by the end of this century. The loss of snow-capped mountains at an alarming rate is a wake-up call to not only Nepal but also all of global community.

Nepal is known for her numerous shiny mountains. It is Sagarmatha (Mt. Everest), the world's highest peak, which gives an identity to Nepal and Nepalis. Mountaineers from around the world have a dream to conquer the tallest peak but not all succeed to make it to the highest point of the earth. Amidst the growing apprehension that the world's tallest peak will become the victim of rising temperature, a new scientific study has brought new fact about it. It has revealed unexpectedly cool temperatures on the slopes of the highest peak due to the impact of glaciers. The findings, published in Nature Geoscience, present unique climate dynamics of Mt. Everest, which contradicts the notion that the temperature rise is warming the Himalayan mountains in the rates that exceed the global average.

A team of around 19 scientists from different countries, including Dr. Sudeep Thakuri, Associate Professor at Tribhuvan University, and led by Dr. Franco Salerno from Italy's National Research Council in Milan were involved in the research that reveals a unique glacier effect on local temperature. They have employed hourly temperature data since 1994 at the Lobuche Pyramid International Laboratory– Observatory (Pyramid Lab) on Mt. Everest's slopes, which is situated at an altitude of 5,035 metres above sea level, according to news report of this daily. The laboratory has the longest weather dataset in the Himalayas. The team has recorded changing weather patterns in the last 15 years, with maximum summer temperatures decreasing at a rate of about 0.04 degrees Celsius per year. This trend also matched with observations from other nearby weather stations at higher elevations.

Experts have explained the reason of local cooling traced on Everest's glacial slope. They say that glaciers exchange heat with the atmosphere at higher elevations, causing the warmer cooling effect. This exchange triggers instability, making the air above glaciers to cool and flow downhill. This results in a cooling effect around the Pyramid Lab and its surroundings. Although the air higher up is getting warmer, the air right above the glacier surface is getting cooler that increases downhill winds and affects lower glacier areas and the surrounding land where the glacier melts. The local cooling protects lower glacier areas from warming and scales down the point where winds from different directions meet. It causes less rainfall at higher elevations and negatively impacts the balance of glacier mass. This new revelation calls for further study about the climate dynamics of the Himalayas and other mountains around the world in relation to climate change impacts.

Curb Children Mortality

ROLI MAHAJAN

Each year, about five million children lose their lives before reaching the age of five according to the seventh annual Goalkeepers Report from the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation. Three out of four of these fatalities happen in the first year of a baby's life, while 2 million babies never get the chance to take their first breath. Despite some progress since the mid-2010s, the decline in these deaths is not happening fast enough.

The authors emphasise that early childhood is pivotal for human development, influencing lifelong health, education and ultimately economic outcomes. However, millions of children worldwide lack access to basic healthcare, nutrition and education, putting them at risk of preventable illnesses and even death.

Amidst these challenges, the report highlights innovations in maternal and child health that could save 2 million lives by the decade's end. These innovations include digital health tools, new vaccines and improved maternal and neonatal care, aiming to ensure children receive necessary care and support even in challenging environments. Furthermore, the report underscores the need for increased investment in early childhood education. Despite proven benefits, many children, particularly in low- and middle-income countries, still lack access to quality preschool programmes.

Another notable report, UNESCO's Global Report on Teachers, published in November, emphasises the crucial role that educators play in promoting inclusive and good early education for all. The report reveals the scarcity of qualified early childhood teachers in many countries, leading to poor-quality education and limited access to early childhood programmes.

In some regions, such as sub-Saharan Africa, Latin America, the Caribbean and the Small Island Developing States (SIDS), the number of qualified teachers in pre-primary education is less than 75 per cent. However, there are large differences between countries, with some doing well (over 90 per cent qualified teachers) and others struggling (less than 50 per cent). Even in industrialised countries such as Australia, graduates are reluctant to accept jobs as pre-school teachers, so there is a greater risk of a teacher shortage at this level.

The Global Report on Teachers emphasises the importance of early childhood education – it is the foundation for lifelong learning and development. This education must be inclusive and equitable, catering for children from different backgrounds and with different abilities. The report moreover recognises the role of parental and community engagement in supporting children's learning and development and calls for concerted efforts to engage these stakeholders.

The involvement of various stakeholders in early-childhood development aligns with policies such as the 2018 Nurturing Care Framework for Early Childhood Development, launched by WHO, UNICEF, the World Bank Group, the Partnership for Maternal, Newborn and Child Health and the Early Childhood Development Action Network. At its core, the Nurturing Care Framework highlights the importance of a supportive ecosystem for children's growth, beginning in the home. 2023's five-year evaluation of the framework revealed a 48 per cent increase in the number of countries with a national policy or action plan for Early Childhood Development (ECD).

Countries such as Iraq, Jordan, Lebanon and Syria focused on caregivers of children to help them deal with stress and learn how to support their children's needs in a humanitarian context. In India, a more inclusive approach involved providing peer support to parents and stakeholders of children with developmental needs. Bangladesh integrated responsive feeding into a parenting programme to address widespread malnutrition and household food insecurity among caregivers of children under age three.

-- Development And Cooperation

Why Mediation Services Fail In Nepal

Mukti Rijal



A few months ago, Mediation Council asked different teams of alternative dispute resolution experts to interrogate and produce suggestions on several issues such as mediation training curriculum and training management, performance and quality of mediation training providers, mediator's code of conduct and many other relevant aspects. These issues have, indeed, significant bearing upon the process and outcome of mediation in enhancing effectiveness towards dispute resolution in Nepal. The teams have already provided their reports to the Council, outlining several suggestions and recommendations on the subjects assigned to them. Needless to say, the council is a regulatory authority provisioned in the mediation act and rules to promote and institutionalise mediation services in Nepal.

The suggestions basically emphasise on the need to make an appropriate institutional arrangements and process to ensure effectiveness of mediation in dispute resolution. It is expected that the Council will carefully assess the suggestions and recommendations, and launch proper steps and measures towards their implementation especially in the areas that it can do without larger dependence upon the government agencies that mostly fail to respond to such pleas and suggestions. This write-up attempts to take note of some of the aspects of the ethics and standard obligations that are central to increase the effectiveness in the delivery of mediation services.

Code of conduct

The research team made rapid appraisal of the state of the compliance of the code of conduct. For this, the team held interactive discussions with different category of respondents particularly the court judges, officials, lawyers and other stakeholders who knew intimately about the operational issues and practical details regarding dispute resolution through mediation. The study seems to be largely concentrated on the court - annexed mediation where lawyers and court officials are generally involved in conducting settlement facilitation of the cases referred by judges using mediation skills.

The report unravels several glaring instances of deviation and violation of conduct standards by those who are involved in the settlement facilitation and resolution of the cases. The report states that the mediators and dispute settlement facilitators pay no due attention, and spare a dedicated time to help resolve the issues through effective use of the mediation skills. According to the report, there are also cases to indicate the dereliction of duty on the part of designated mediators. The mediators, as mentioned in the report, pay no heed to schedule and convene discussion between the litigating parties to clarify and resolve the issues inherent in the disputes. This lack of seriousness and attention on the part of mediators to attend to their duty eventually leads to lapsing of the time- period allotted in conducting and closing mediation sessions without yielding any outcomes because of the failure to act in prescribed period.

Furthermore, the rapacious breach of the code of conduct surrounds the issue regarding remuneration to be paid to the mediators for the offer of their dispute resolution services. The report brings to fore the instances in which mediators tend to ask for additional and more monetary compensation and pecuniary benefits than prescribed. Moreover, the lawyers and court officials, as the report discloses, oftentimes fight for slots, favours and the spaces in mediating cases especially with a view to accrue undue pecuniary benefits.

> Effective implementation and enforcement of the code of conduct can contribute to enhance trust and creditability of mediation services Nepal.

According to code of ethics recognised as global standard, a mediator should neither give nor accept a gift, favour, loan or other item of value that raises a question as to the mediator's actual or perceived impartiality.

Moreover, a mediator should also avoid a conflict of interest or the appearance of a conflict of interest during and after mediation. A conflict of interest can arise from involvement by a mediator with the subject matter of the dispute or from any relationship between a mediator and any disputing party, whether past or present, personal or professional, that reasonably raises a question of a mediator's impartiality and independence. Likewise, a mediator needs to mediate only when the mediator has the necessary competence to satisfy the reasonable expectations of the parties. Any person may be selected as a mediator, provided that the parties are satisfied with the mediator's competence and qualifications. It is important to note that training, experience in mediation, skills, cultural understandings and other qualities are necessary for mediator competence. A person who offers to serve as a mediator creates the expectation that he or she is competent enough to mediate effectively to resolve disputes.

Confidentiality

A mediator should attend educational programmes and related activities to maintain and enhance knowledge and skills related to mediation. A mediator should be available for the parties' information relevant to the mediator's training, education, experience and approach to conduct mediation. If a mediator, during the course of mediation, decides that he or she cannot conduct the mediation effectively, he or she should discuss that issues with the parties concerned and take appropriate steps to address the situation. The steps may include, but not limited to, withdrawing or requesting appropriate assistance. If a mediator's ability to conduct mediation is impaired by drugs, alcohol, medication or other reasons, the mediator should not conduct the mediation and be liable to face action.

It is universally maintained as a standard that a mediator should maintain the confidentiality of all information obtained during mediation unless otherwise agreed to by the parties. If a mediator participates in teaching, research or evaluation of mediation, the mediator should protect the anonymity of the parties and abide by their reasonable expectations regarding confidentiality. A mediator who meets with any persons in private session during mediation shall not convey directly or indirectly to any other person, any information that was obtained during that private session without the consent of the disclosing person. These aforesaid ethical standards are more or less global creeds which need to be adhered to by mediators in all jurisdictions including Nepal. Effective implementation and enforcement of the code of conduct can contribute to enhance trust and creditability of mediation services Nepal.

(The author is presently associated with Policy Research Institute (PRI) as a senior research fellow. rijalmukti@gmail.com)

Ensure Cyber Security For Biomedical Device

Rabi Dhungel



According to KPMG (Klynveld Peat Marwick Goerdeler) advisory on medical device, annual sales of biomedical devices will reach eight hundred billion by 2030. This huge demand of growth is primarily driven by the connectivity of medical devices. These projections reflect increasing demand for innovative new devices (like wearables) and services (like health data). The increase of aging population in China and India unlocks the immense potential in emerging markets.

Managing cyber security programmes in biomedical devices require unique approach to people, processes, and technologies, which are vulnerable to the cyber security and safety. The connected nature of medical devices is prone to cyber risks. Health Deliver Organization (HDO) must adhere to strict standards to ensure patient privacy and safety. Unlike in Europe, cyber security and privacy regulation in the US is fragmented across regulatory agencies and state and federal jurisdiction. Some of them are PCI-DSS, HIPAA, FERPA, etc. The FDA (Food and Drug Administration) is the regulatory body for biomedical devices in the United States. FDA has published multiple cyber security guidelines.

Safety

Cyber security programmes are managed quite differently but the technology elements of cyber security have common denominators across the industries, but processes and the talent vary. Cyber security programmes in biomedical devices are often driven by safety and privacy of the patients. The users of the devices are clinical professionals, researchers, biomedical engineers, patients, and health professionals. Confidentiality, integrity, availability and safety play a crucial role in biomedical devices. Compromise on any of the quad can be detrimental for patient safety, privacy, and health records.

Devices need to strike a delicate balance among the amount of data generated, captured, and transmitted. The data drives innovation, personalised clinical care and therapy. Data is also vulnerable to hackers as the attack vectors and digital surfaces increases dramatically with rapid increase in connectivity and digitisation of clinical processes. Artificial intelligence and machine learning in biomedical devices requires a large set of medical data. Biomedical devices provide unique opportunities to decentralise machine learning and artificial intelligence in the patient level, HDO level and geographic cohort. Biomedical devices are becoming increasingly sophisticated and are collecting more data than ever before.

The FDA's cyber security guidelines focus on pre-market and post-market cyber security. It includes Quality System Regulations (QSR), Secure Product Development Framework (SPDF), SBOM (Software Bill of Materials), vulnerability management, disclosure requirements, and design control requirements. Continuous monitoring of cyber threats and cyber security as a TPLC (Total Product Life Cycle) and cyber risk management is the core for cyber security and safety. The FDA guidelines recommend AAMI TIR57/07, SW86, NIST 800-30, NIST CSF and Medical Device and Health IT Joint Security Plan (JSP), ISO14971 for safety risks and IEC 81001-5-1. Safety and security risks are reduced to an acceptable level and continuously monitored when new vulnerabilities are identified and mitigated during product life cycle.

> Law enforcement agencies should develop cyber operations expertise so that they can provide emergency cyber operations at hospitals and save patients life.

The severity of the safety and cyber issues is determined by the type of device, whether it is Class II or Class III. Cyber security risks in healthcare are primarily shared between the medical device manufacturers and HDO. It is difficult to manage the cyber security programmes in a shared responsibility model but due to the interconnected nature of software systems, rules of engagement and processes should be developed between different stakeholders including HDO, cloud service providers and manufacturers. User manuals, labels, communication plans, complaint management and service level agreements are tools for shared responsibility of the security.

The medical device product life cycle is three times longer than other types of software and devices. There is a substantial security debt in medical devices because risk-averse nature of the industry but patchability and security debt increases exponentially with the time. The proper remediation plan needs to be developed if there is major upgrade or recall. Biomedical devices are moving to the next generation, where they will be constantly connected to the internet and provide data to HMOs, doctors, patients, and other healthcare stakeholders on their mobile devices. Real-time monitoring systems of biomedical devices and security operations teams are required to monitor and mitigate cyber threats.

Data security

Cyber security risk mitigation approaches such as fail fast, DevSecOps, and walk-crawl-run may not be well-suited for all products in biomedical, space, aerospace industries, and military where safety is critical and development processes are owned by multifunctional teams with clear separation of duties. These approaches may introduce new risks or exacerbate existing ones. For example, fail fast could lead to the release of unsafe products, DevSecOps could introduce security vulnerabilities that trigger safety issues and walk-crawl-run could lead to delays in the development of critical systems. Instead, biomedical industries and HDO need to adopt more tailored cyber security risk mitigation approaches that consider safety and security requirements of the patient.

Nepal should enact a new policy for the data security of biomedical devices and healthcare data. Nurses, doctors, and HDOs should be trained on clinical cyber security and the privacy of patient. Law enforcement agencies should develop cyber operations expertise so that they can provide emergency cyber operations at hospitals and save patients life. Cyber security is a national security. Nepal has failed to uphold the quality and safety in the transportation sector, result of which is loss of human life due to poor safety controls in automobiles. In Nepal, biomedical device industry can help the transportation industry to build safe and resilient systems that safe human life.

(Dhungel is a cyber-security practitioner based in USA. ravi@esrtech.io)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

December 21, 1973

Women' Handicraft Centre For Dharan

Dharan, Dec.20: The Sunsari district unit of the Nepal Women' organisation at its recent meeting decided to open a women' handicraft centre in Dharan, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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Please email your contributions to:

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Or send them to
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READER'S MAIL

Respect One Another's Differences



I am writing in reference to a news report titled "*Multi-cultural democratic society strengthens national unity: PM Prachanda*" which was published on December 16, 2023 on the digital version of this daily. Certainly, Nepal has diversity in religion and culture. Numerous religions thrive with one another in a state of harmony. However, every now and then this peace is disrupted amid controversial acts.

But the nation should ensure that this religious and cultural harmony flourishes in the setting of democratic society. Social harmony should be promoted by encouraging all religious and cultural sects to foster amongst one another. In a democratic society such as Nepal, there is place for multi-cultural, multi-religious, and multi-ethnic communities.

The Nepal government's priority should be to ensure that social harmony continues to thrive as Nepali people continue to respect one another's differences. Likewise, the democracy which is the foundation of the nation's stability should be promoted so that everyone can have an equal voice and saying for national unity.

Sambriddhi Neupane
Chitwan

TAILPIECE

A man walked into a bar, sat down, ordered 3 shots of whiskey, drank them, then left. This continued daily for several weeks. Curious, the bartender asked him one day, "Why do you always order three shots of whiskey?"

The man answered, "Because my two brothers and I always used to have one shot each, and since they've both passed on, I've continued to order the three shots in their honour. "The bartender thought that this was a very noble thing to do, and welcomed the man every time he visited the bar.

Two weeks later, the man walked into the bar for his daily visit and ordered two shots of whiskey. Surprised, the bartender asked him why he only ordered two when had had always been ordering three.

The man answered, "Oh, I've decided to stop drinking."

Hamas chief in Egypt for talks on Gaza truce, hostage release

AFP
Gaza Strip (Palestinian Territories), Dec. 20

The leader of Hamas visited Egypt on Wednesday as hopes grew that Israel and the Palestinian militant group may be inching toward another truce and hostage release deal in the Gaza war.

The Qatar-based Hamas chief, Ismail Haniyeh, arrived in Cairo for discussions on the "aggression in the Gaza Strip and other matters", the group said in a statement.

He was due to meet Egypt's spy chief for talks on "stopping the aggression and the war to prepare an agreement for the release of prisoners", a source close to the group told AFP.

Haniyeh -- who earlier met Iranian Foreign Minister Hossein Amir-Abdollahian in Qatar -- was heading a "high-level delegation" to Egypt, a frequent mediator between Israel and the Palestinians, the source said.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu had told hostage families late Tuesday that he had twice sent his spy chief to Europe in efforts to "free our hostages".

"It's our duty, I'm responsible for the release of all the hostages," the premier told the relatives of some of the 129 captives still believed to be held in Gaza. "Saving them is a supreme task.

"I have just sent the head of Mossad to Europe twice to promote a process to free our hostages. I will spare no effort on the subject, and our duty is to bring them all back."

US news site Axios reported Monday that Mossad chief David Barnea had met CIA director Bill Burns and Qatari Prime Minister Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al Thani in Europe.



PHOTO: AFP

Hamas leader Ismail Haniyeh, on the right, meets Iranian Foreign Minister Hossein Amir Abdollahian in Doha, in a handout picture from the Iranian foreign ministry.

Qatar, backed by Egypt and the United States, helped broker a week-long truce in November in which 80 Israeli hostages were freed in exchange for 240 Palestinian prisoners.

Axios has also reported that Israel had offered to pause the fighting for at least one week in exchange for more than three dozen hostages held by Hamas.

The war began when Hamas militants burst out of Gaza on October 7, killing around 1,140 people in Israel, mostly civilians, and abducting about 250, according an AFP tally based on Israeli figures.

Vowing to destroy Hamas, Israel began a campaign of bombardment, and then a ground invasion, that Gaza's Hamas-run health ministry says have killed 19,667 people, mostly women and children.

Israeli President Isaac Herzog also said Tuesday his country was "ready for another humanitarian pause and additional humanitarian aid in order to enable the release of hostages".

Palestinian militant group Islamic Jihad, meanwhile, released video footage it claimed showed two hostages alive in its custody in Gaza, ramping up pressure on Israel.

The UN Security Council was set to vote Wednesday on a resolution calling for a pause in the conflict, three diplomatic sources told AFP, after two previous votes were delayed as members wrangled over wording.

The latest version of the text calls for the "suspension" of hostilities, the sources said.

The US vetoed a previous ceasefire resolution, sparking condemnation by Palestinian and humanitarian groups, which urged more action to help civilians caught in the conflict.

For now, fighting was raging unabated after Israeli military spokesman Daniel Hagari said Tuesday that troops were expanding operations in southern Gaza's Khan Yunis area.

"We must dismantle Hamas, and it will take as long as needed," he said, as the army said 133 soldiers had been killed since ground operations began in late October.

French House adopts immigration law

AFP
Paris, Dec. 20

The French parliament on Tuesday passed an immigration bill backed by the government of President Emmanuel Macron after he faced a major rebellion within his own party over the far right's support of the toughened-up legislation.

The lower house voted in favour of the legislation by a wide majority, with the ruling party in the end not needing the support of Marine Le Pen's far-right National Rally (RN) to push the bill through.

Various amendments have seen the immigration measures further tightened from when the bill was originally submitted, with the left accusing the government of caving in to pressure from the far right.

Le Pen endorsed the strengthened bill but key left-leaning members of Macron's Renaissance Party and allied factions indicated they could no longer support it, with several ministers reportedly threatening to resign.

"We can rejoice in ideological progress, an ideological victory even for the National Rally, since this is now enshrined into law as a national priority," said Le Pen, a three-time presidential candidate who leads the RN's lawmakers in parliament and is widely expected to stand again for president in 2027.

The RN had previously said it would vote against the bill or abstain. French media dubbed her surprise move a "kiss of death" for Macron's party.

The bill had been voted down without even being debated in the National Assembly last week, in a major blow to Macron.

The upper-house Senate had earlier also passed the legislation, which then went through the lower house with 349 in favour and 186 against.

A key element of the law is that social security benefits for foreigners will now be conditioned on five years of presence in France, or 30 months for those who have jobs.

Migration quotas can also now be agreed and there are measures for dual-national convicts being stripped of French nationality as well.

Prominent left-leaning Renaissance MP Sacha Houlie had said he would vote against the legislation and called on others to follow, with some sources saying that around 30 pro-Macron MPs would do so.

In a sign of the seriousness of the situation, Macron called a meeting of his ruling party at the Elysee Palace ahead of the vote, party sources told AFP.

According to a participant at the meeting, Macron said he would submit the bill to a new reading rather than promulgate it if it were passed only with the help of the votes from Le Pen's RN.

Health Minister Aurelien Rousseau, Higher Education Minister Sylvie Retailleau and Housing Minister Patrice Vergriete met Prime Minister Elisabeth Borne and warned they could resign, sources told AFP.

"The majority has stood together, the far right's plan has failed," Borne said on social media platform X after the vote.

Rousseau delivered a letter of resignation on Tuesday evening to Borne, who did not say whether she would accept it, according to a ministerial source confirming a report by the daily Le Figaro.

Congo votes for president

AP
Kinshasa, Congo, Dec. 20

Congo headed to the polls Wednesday to vote for president as authorities scrambled to finalize preparations in an election facing steep logistical and security challenges, with voting starting nearly 2 1/2 hours late in the capital.

Some 44 million people — almost half the population — were expected to vote, but many, including several million who were displaced by conflict in the vast country's east, could struggle to cast their ballots. The fighting has prevented 1.5 million people from registering to vote.

Voter Raymond Yuma in the capital of Kinshasa said he's voting for hope. "When you wake up in the morning you're hoping for good things, good work, and I want security," said Yuma. He sat beside three other people on a bench waiting in line for the doors to open. None of their voting cards were legible.

In eastern Congo, people said they weren't finding their names on voting lists.

"The voters displayed on lists at the polling station are fewer than those who are lining up. I can't find my name on the list and this could cause scuffles here because I also want to vote," said Jules Kambale at a polling station in Goma.

Waiting for polls to open during the more than two-hour delay, people grew agitated and began arguing, particularly in the capital.

Both outside observers and locals have warned of challenges that could affect the credibility of the vote in one of Africa's largest nations and one whose mineral resources are increasingly crucial to the global economy.

On the eve of the vote, some polling stations in Kinshasa told Associated Press journalists they were still waiting for materials. Thousands of stations, particularly in remote areas, might still not have what they need on Wednesday.

A major concern is that ink on voting cards has smudged, making many illegible. That means people could be turned away from polling stations. In addition, the voter registration list hasn't been properly audited.

"The organization of the elections raises lots of doubt regarding the credibility, the transparency and the reliability of the results," said Bienvenu Matumo, a member of LUCHA, a local rights group.

A candidate needs a majority of votes in the first round to win.

President Felix Tshisekedi seeks his second and final five-year term, running against about 20 other candidates. His main rival appeared to be Moise Katumbi, the former governor of Katanga province and a millionaire businessperson whose campaign in 2018 was thwarted by the previous regime of former President Joseph Kabila.

But the opposition remains fractured, making Tshisekedi the likely favourite.

The son of a late, popular opposition figure, he has spent much of his presidency trying to consolidate power over state institutions and working to overcome a crisis of legitimacy after a contested election five years ago.

Some voters didn't want to disclose who they were backing, but Kinshasa is a Tshisekedi stronghold.

India court to weigh future of Gyanvapi mosque

AFP
New Delhi, Dec. 20

An Indian court has weighed into one of the country's most bitter religious disagreements by greenlighting cases on whether a mosque in the holy city of Varanasi should be opened to Hindu worshippers.

The Gyanvapi mosque was built in the 17th century by the Muslim Mughal empire then ruling over much of India in a city where Hindu faithful from across the country cremate their loved ones by the Ganges river.

It is among several Islamic places of worship that Hindu activists, backed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's party, have sought for decades to reclaim for their faith in disputes that have previously sparked deadly religious riots.

The Allahabad High Court on Tuesday directed a lower bench to evaluate petitions on the future of the mosque, which historians say was built over the demolished ruins of a temple to the Hindu deity Shiva.

The decision would permit several civil suits to proceed from Hindus demanding the right to worship at the Gyanvapi site and the restoration of a temple on its grounds.

Presiding justice Rohit Ranjan Agarwal ordered a lower court to rule on the site's future within six months, describing the dispute as a matter of "national importance".

"It is not a suit between two individual parties. It affects two major communities of the country," he said, according to local media reports published Wednesday.



PHOTO : AFP

The 17th century Gyanvapi mosque is among several Islamic places of worship that Hindu activists have sought for decades to reclaim for their faith.

Emboldened right-wing Hindu groups have laid claim to several Muslim sites of worship they say were built atop ancient temples during Mughal rule.

Hindu zealots in 1992 demolished the centuries-old Babri Masjid in the nearby city of Ayodhya, sparking sectarian riots that killed more than 1,000 people nationwide.

A decades-long court battle over the future of the ruined mosque's site ended in 2019 when the Supreme Court permitted the construction of a temple to the deity Ram, who according to scripture was born in the city.

Prime Minister Modi, whose party has campaigned for the temple for decades, will inaugurate the structure next month ahead of national elections in which he is widely expected to win a third term.

Modi's party has come to be the dominant force in Indian politics thanks to its muscular appeals to the country's Hindu majority, emboldening the faith's hardliners.

Calls for India to enshrine Hindu supremacy in law have rapidly grown louder since he took office in 2014, making its 210-million-odd Muslims increasingly anxious about their future.

PRISM

Lost dog found after 6 years living on her own

West Sussex: A dog who fled from her new family within 24 hours of being adopted was found in England after living on her own in the woods for more than 6 years.

Lost Dog Recovery UK South said team members were alerted to a stray dog in Crawley Down, West Sussex, in late November, so cameras were set up to investigate whether it was a loose canine or a pet that was allowed to roam free.

They discovered the dog was a black Patterdale terrier, and neighbors told the rescuers they had been feeding the stray dog for years.

The dog was lured into a trap baited with chicken, and the rescue group was shocked to learn the canine had been reported missing 6 1/2 years earlier by a family who had adopted her fewer than 24 hours before she fled.

90-year-old woman earns master's degree

Texas: A 90-year-old woman became the eldest University of North Texas student to complete her coursework when she earned her master's degree in interdisciplinary studies.

Minnie Payne told UNT officials she attended junior college for only a short time after graduating high school in 1950, but decided to return to her education after retiring from her 30-year career as a transcriptionist and word processor at age 68.

She attended Texas Women's University, taking three journalism classes and a business class at the UNT campus.

(Agencies)

TODAY IN HISTORY

AD 69 – The Roman Senate declares Vespasian emperor of Rome, the last in the Year of the Four Emperors.
1124 – Pope Honorius II is consecrated, having been elected after the controversial dethroning of Pope Celestine II.
1140 – After a siege of several weeks, the city of Weinsberg and its castle surrender to Conrad III of Germany.
1237 – The city of Ryazan is sacked by the Mongol army of Batu Khan.[4]
1620 – Plymouth Colony: William Bradford and the Mayflower Pilgrims land near what is now known as Plymouth Rock in Plymouth, Massachusetts.
1826 – American settlers in Nacogdoches, Mexican Texas, declare their independence, starting the Fredonian Rebellion.
1832 – Egyptian–Ottoman War: Egyptian forces decisively defeat Ottoman troops at the Battle of Konya.

Music gives Gaza children respite from war horrors

AFP
Rafah (Palestinian Territories), Dec. 20

It takes a while but slowly the children gathered around volunteer entertainer Ruaa Hassuna in a Gaza camp start clapping along as her music offers some respite from the horrors around them.

Smiles light up the faces of the children, huddled amid the tents outside the south Gaza town of Rafah which shelter hundreds of thousands of Palestinians driven from their homes by more than two months of relentless Israeli bombardment.

Hassuna is part of a troupe of more than a dozen volunteer entertainers who travel from camp to makeshift camp on a mission to provide children with some escape, however brief, from the death and destruction they have witnessed.

The 23-year-old plays the oud, a lute-like stringed instrument popular across the Middle East. Other volunteers entertain the children with slapstick, acrobatics, story-telling or dance.



PHOTO: AFP

The troupe of entertainers is the brainchild of returning expatriate Awni Farhat who says he wanted to do something to address the impact of the war on children's mental health.

"We use whatever means we can to remove the children from the war," says the 23-year-old. "The aim of getting them to sing is to alleviate their stress."

Hassuna says that when her young audiences hear her oud, they "no longer hear the hum of the drones" deployed by the Israeli army, instead immersing themselves in the music.

The United Nations says children make up half of the 1.9 million Palestinians displaced since the onset of the Israel-Hamas war.

They have been forced to abandon their daily routines and live under Israeli bombardment since Hamas's October 7 attacks on Israel killed about 1,140 people, according to an AFP count based on Israel figures.

Hassuna's troupe travels to a different camp every day, putting on a three-hour performance in each.

"It's an important project because, from what we've observed, the psychological state of the children is very bad," said returning expatriate Awni Farhat, the person behind the initiative.

This space "allows them to unburden themselves of the psychological problems created by this war", said Farhat, who lives in the Netherlands but returned to Gaza during a week-long humanitarian truce in late November.

The UN children's agency, UNICEF, has described the Gaza Strip as "the most dangerous place in the world" for a child.

Speaking after a two-week visit to the besieged coastal enclave, UNICEF spokesman James Elder said he had witnessed children hospitalised for amputations who were then "killed in those hospitals" by Israeli bombardments.

The health ministry in the Hamas-run territory says more than 19,667 people have been killed in Gaza during the war, most of them women or children.

Many of the children in the troupe's audiences are hardened beyond their years, their innocence shattered by fear and bereavement.

"I want to forget my worries and forget the people I've lost," said 15-year-old Nizar Shaheen, adding that he felt "suffocated" by life in the camps.

"I want to live my childhood like we did before," he said, adding: "We don't know where to go. Today, there's no food, no water, there's nothing."



PHOTO: KABIN ADHIKARI/TRN

Vehicles are still moving around Nyatapola temple, a World Heritage site area in Bhaktapur, though Kathmandu has already restricted vehicular movement around World Heritage site of Hanumandhoka Durbar Square.

'Social values main basis for laws related to social sites'

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 20

Minister for Communications and Information Technology, Rekha Sharma, has said that Nepali norms and values are the minimum basis for the use of social networking sites.

At an interaction with stakeholders on formulation of laws related to social networking sites in Nepal organised by the Ministry here on Wednesday, Minister Sharma pointed out the need of formulating laws related to use of social sites making the social norms and values as the basis for it.

"It does not mean that social sites should not be used in the era of information technology as it has becoming the lifestyle of the Nepali society. But formulation of laws has been realized in order to harmonize the use of social sites with values of the Nepali Society. The Ministry has been preparing draft to formulate the laws," she said.

The Communications Minister viewed that the Nepali society is different than the western society and laid emphasis on the need of keeping the freedom of expression in centre while formulating laws related to social sites.

Stating that guidelines have already been issued to make the use of social sites systematic, Minister Sharma added the guidelines could be the important basis of laws formulation and self-regulation, awareness and regulation.

On the occasion, legal practitioners, IT experts and various stakeholders suggested about different aspects to be included in laws related to social sites.

One more Nepali dies in Russia-Ukraine war

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20

Kundan Singh Nagal, a Nepali citizen working in the Russian Army, has died in the war between Russia and Ukraine.

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) informed in a statement on Wednesday that it received information about the tragic death of Nagal. With this, the number Nepalis deceased in the war has reached six.

The MoFA has urged Russia through its Ambassador in Nepal to send the bodies of the Nepali citizens who died after enlisting in the Russian army to Nepal as soon as possible and to provide compensation to the families of the victims including the injured.

Similarly, it has reiterated its request to the Russian government that Nepali citizens should not be recruited in the Russian Army and that the enlisted Nepali citizens should be immediately repatriated to Nepal.

"We have firmly asked the Russian government to provide the number of Nepali citizens who have joined the Russian Army, the number of injured Nepalis and their condition at the earliest," read the statement.

Meanwhile, the Ministry has requested the Ukrainian government through diplomatic channels to release the Nepalis detained there and send them back to Nepal as soon as possible. Bibek Khatri of Rajapur in Bardiya, Siddartha Dhakal of Mandan Deupur in Kavrepalanchwok, Bikas Rai of Letang in Morang and Pratik Pun of Runtigadhi in Rolpa are in captivity in Ukraine.

Stating that serious attention of the Government of Nepal has been drawn to the detainment of Nepalis in Ukraine, the MoFA informed that diplomatic initiatives are being taken by other means including the International Committee of the Red Cross for their release and return to Nepal.

"Ordinary citizens, except for those involved in government work, scholarships of the Russian government and those involved in professional business, can travel to Russia only with a No Objection Certificate (NOC) issued by the Consular Service Department under the MoFA," said the Ministry.

It also appealed to everyone to travel to Russia only with an NOC issued by the Nepali Embassies and Consulates General in the respective countries even if they travel through Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, United Arab Emirates, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Qatar and Bahrain.

Earlier, the MoFA had warned Nepali citizens not to go to security-related work in war-torn countries.

Under the traditionally existing agreement, Nepali citizens are not allowed to join foreign armies other than the national armies of some friendly countries. The Ministry reiterated that there is no policy of the Government of Nepal to grant permission to its citizens to join the foreign armies.

CONTRACTOR ASKED TO SPEED UP ICP WORKS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20

Joint Secretary of the Ministry of External Affairs of India, Anurag Srivastava, has instructed the contractor of the Nepalgunj Integrated Check Post (ICP) to speed up the construction work and complete the remaining works within a month.

Although the ICP was inaugurated virtually on June 1 this year jointly by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' and his Indian counterpart Narendra Modi during the former's India visit, construction of water tank and other structures and installation of CCTV connection, networking and fire-fighting system have not been completed. It is estimated that it would take a month to complete the remaining work, Nepal Intermodal Transport Development Board (NITDB), an agency under the Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies (MoICS), informed in a statement on Wednesday.

Ashish Gajurel, Executive Director of the NITDB, said that all preparations have been completed by the NITDB for the operation of the ICP and informed that a request has been made to the Indian Embassy in Kathmandu through the MoICS for the transfer of the facility to the NITDB.

A team comprised of MEA of India's Joint Secretary Srivastava, Chief District Officer of Banke, Shrawan Kumar Pokharel, Head of Nepalgunj Customs, Dhruba Raj Bishwakarma, Head of Urban Development and Building Construction Department, Nepalgunj Office, Bijay Keshar Khanal, Superintendents Nepal Police and Armed Police Force of Nepalgunj, and representatives of Land Port Authority of India, ICP Rupaidiha, Rupaidiha Customs, Seema Suraksha Bal of India jointly conducted an inspection of the ICP on Tuesday.

Gajurel said the board has made preparations to bring the facility into operation immediately after it was handed over to NITDB. "We have been coordinating with all concerned agencies and the private sector, so there will not be any problem in bringing the ICP into operation," he said.

Army chief for transparency in Fast Track project

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20

Chief of the Army Staff (CoAS) General Prabhu Ram Sharma has promised not to allow corruption in the Kathmandu/Madhes Fast Track (Expressway) project.

Responding to questions asked by the lawmakers and members of the State Affairs and Good Governance Committee of the House of Representatives on Wednesday morning, CoAS Sharma said that the army would not look for money.

He has also claimed that the work done by the Nepali Army would be transparent.

"We do not make mistakes, the army works according to rules, laws and transparency", he said.

"I do personally say that there should be no mistake in the project," said the Army Chief.

He said that the Nepali Army had never asked for the fast track project from the government, saying that the army was being attacked on the issue of the fast track.

"The army did not ask for the project, you (parliamentarians) gave it to us," he said.

It takes nine months to cut just four trees along the project site, he said. "The trees that I showed to the Prime Minister and the Defence Minister have not yet been cut," he said.

"Consultants should be hired promptly to advance the work. We have also used Nepali consultants so that money does not go abroad as much as possible," he said.

Even if the work is not completed by 2027, the track will be opened and the vehicle can reach Nijgadh, but the rules of EIA should be changed, CoAS Sharma said.

Mentioning the obstruction in Khokana of Lalitpur and the anger of the locals, General Sharma said that it took six months to approve the DPR.

"Land has not been obtained or pooled; trees have not been cut yet. We have looked at the social and cultural aspects of the impact and what we need to do near the Dukuchhap area where there are historical temples," he said.

"We are doing work at a cheap price saving Rs. 12 billion of the state," he said. Complaints have been coming according to political interests, he said.

CoAS Sharma claimed that the Fast Track Project did not award the contract to Kalika Construction alone, it was given according to the rules and regulations mentioned in the public procurement regulations.

"We have also asked the district administration office, the university and got the answer that his date of birth is ok," he said.

Sharma said that he also checked the citizenship of another general, Ashok Sigdel. He has two citizenship certificates. One issued from Rupandehi and the other from Jajarkot, but the age is 17 in both the certificate,' he said.

General Sharma said, "It was a game of elements to show the army wrong all the time."



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Chief of the Army Staff General Prabhu Ram Sharma attending the parliamentary committee meeting in Singha Durbar, Kathmandu on Wednesday.

There occurred a hot debate among the parliamentarians and the CoAS regarding the dispute seen in the date of birth and certificate of some senior generals including Major General Tara Dhwoj Pandey.

Committee member of CPN-UML Raghu Panta questioned the CoAS about the rumours and reality of General Pandey's certificate.

After Panta, lawmaker Rajendra Pandey questioned whether Pandey would get impunity just by resigning from the post.

In response to the question, General Sharma said that there was no recommendation made for the promotion of Tara Dhwoj Pandey. He said the promotion notice was just published.

Another lawmaker Rajendra Rai suggested that the Army Chief should think ahead and act accordingly. He said, "The Commander-in-Chief should think beforehand while taking any decision."

Likewise, parliamentarian Gagan Thapa said that a serious question had arisen as to whether the army should carry out defined responsibilities or give responsibility for building national infrastructure.

"A serious question has arisen whether the army should carry out defined responsibilities or build infrastructure, we should find an answer to these issues. The answer of the political decisions cannot be found in the committee now," said Thapa.

Hierarchy row surfaces in NC Madhes Province

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20

Eight leaders of the Nepali Congress Madhes Province Committee wrote a note of dissent on Wednesday over a row of the hierarchy of central leaders during its first province-level conference being held on Thursday.

Senior leader Ram Saroj Yadav and others wrote a note of dissent on Wednesday's meeting as the leaders of the establishment faction denied giving the second hierarchy to NC leader Dr. Shekhar Koirala. They also drew the attention of the committee to give the second hierarchy to Dr. Koirala. They also made public their disagreement in writing.

The conference is being held on Thursday in Janakpur, Dhanusa. NC president Sher Bahadur Deuba is scheduled to inaugurate the conference.

The Provincial Committee did not put Dr. Koirala in the second-ranking after Deuba as earlier when Dr. Koirala was kept in the second hierarchy in Gandiki Provincial and Lumbini Provincial conferences respectively. Other districts too had given Koirala the second position in their conferences.

The meeting that held on Wednesday decided to give the second position to NC vice-president Purna Bahadur Khadka after Deuba.

After the hierarchy dispute, Dr. Koirala is likely to remain absent in the conference on Thursday.

Meanwhile, our Janakpur correspondent wrote: Preparations for the conference have been completed.

Organising a press meet on Wednesday, NC Madhes Province Committee chair Krishna Prasad Yadav said the conference would exert pressure to implement federalism as provisioned in the constitution. He informed that the committee meeting that was held on Wednesday took five-point decisions.

Next action plan will be based...

During the meeting, Chief Secretary of the government Dr. Baikunth Aryal, emphasized the importance of introducing packages to increase agricultural productivity and ensuring the scientific management of land.

He urged state research-oriented agencies to demonstrate a heightened sense of seriousness in their endeavours.

Likewise, Eak Narayan Aryal, the Secretary of the Office of the Prime Minister said that while the first-quarter progress of the fiscal year 2023/24 was commendable, it has not precisely met the established targets.

Similarly, Govinda Sharma, the Secretary of the Ministry of Agriculture, highlighted the notable efficiency in the procurement and distribution of chemical fertilisers this year.

Informing that Nepal is self-sufficient in eggs and meat, Secretary Rewati Raman Paudel said there was an ongoing effort towards achieving self-sufficiency in milk production.

Similarly, Finance Secretary Krishnahari Pushkar said there was a gradual improvement in the economy.

Concluding the meeting, Prime Minister Prachanda emphasised that delivering results to the nation and its people requires collective efforts and shared experiences rather than individual endeavours.

CIAA asks govt for steps to...

Extensive study of public corporations about their human resource requirement and curtailing of unnecessary staffs have been suggested.

CIAA has instructed for steps to control hundi money transfer, crypto currency and other illegal transactions. The commission has suggested the government for steps to control corruption, transparency in distribution of university grants, financial irregularities in foreign employment, initial public offering (IPO) share floating, tax evasion, leakage in fuel transportation and storage and upgradation of water supply in Kathmandu.

The commission has asked the government to ensure supply of chemical fertiliser, quality enhancement of Nepal Telecom's services and transparency in public procurement process.

The CIAA has asked to control the tendency of increasing facilities to employees, bonus distribution, taking meeting allowances in different committees comprising internal staffs only and increasing facilities without the permission of the Finance Ministry by public service enterprises.

It has also asked to control in unnecessary foreign trips, hire unnecessary employees on contract and daily wage basis and appointment of management consultants, legal advisors and communication experts in public corporations.

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Health & Population
Department of Health Services
Management Division
Pachali, Teku, Kathmandu, Nepal

Notice for Price bid open

Date of Notice : 21 December 2023

Pursuant to clause 31(4) and (5) of Public Procurement Regulation 2064, this is to notify all the bidders that the following substantially responsive technical bidder has been selected for further evaluation as per the Invitation for Bids published on The Rising Nepal dated 9 October 2023 **IFB No DOHS/G/ICB-26/FWD/2080-81/Procurement of OCP** and DOHS decides to open the price bid on 5 Jan 2024 on 12:00 Hr.

S.N.	Successful Bidders Name and Address
1	Revachi International Pvt.Ltd.; Pepsicola, Kathmandu
2	Universal Tradelink, Chhetrapati, Kathmandu

Mahajatra's shooting nears completion

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20



The shooting of 'Mahajatra' has been going on at Khulamanch, Kathmandu.

Director Pradip Bhattarai said that due to the lack of a proper shooting studio, they were shooting three different scenes simultaneously in Khulamancha. One of the scenes shot shows actor Arun Chhetri and model Ashma Vishwakarma dancing to the song 'Kya Ramro'.

The song, featuring lyrics by Eknarayan Bhandari is choreographed by Kaviraj Gahatraj, while Ashish Aviral has composed music and Asmita Adhikari and Ashish have the vocals.

Meanwhile, the climax scene is also being shot on the same stage.

The star-studded cast includes actors Haribansha Acharya, Bipin Karki, Rabindra Singh Baniya, Rabindra Jha, Barsha Raut, and others, with over 100 choruses contributing to the song.

Director Bhattarai said that the song was crafted for promotional purposes, including all the available artists in the song. Producer Max Dipesh Khatri said that after completing the shooting, the team plans to initiate post-production collaboration.

The shooting was expected to conclude on Wednesday evening, adhering to the predetermined schedule.

'Mahajatra', the third instalment in the successful series following 'Jatra' and 'Jatrai Jatra', addresses the challenges encountered while pursuing dreams to enhance life and seize opportunities. Director Bhattarai highlighted that the film combines elements of laughter and tears to convey a compelling narrative.

The film features a diverse casts, including Arjun Jung Shahi, Prakash Ghimire, Rajaram Paudel, Praween Khatiwada, Divya Dev, Suman Karki, Shishir Bangdel, Gaumaya Gurung and Arbin Khadka.

MSM Entertainment has already acquired the international screening rights for the film, produced by Yagyashwar Poudel in collaboration with Max Dipesh Khatri.

The film is scheduled to be released worldwide on March 22 next year.

The film's cinematography is handled by Purushottam Pradhan while Kumar Maharjan serves as the fight director.

Shrestha's 'Parkhi Base Timilai' to be staged from January 12

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20



Two posters of director Deepak Shrestha's upcoming film, 'Parkhi Base Timilai' have recently been unveiled.

The movie, set to hit screens on January 12, delves into the themes of love and pain.

'Parkhi Base' film is director Shrestha's 27 films.

Kiran Shrestha and Rakshya Budathoki have marked their debut as actors through this film.

The director said that the two public posters convey the essence of the movie, with one depicting the love between the two lead characters and the other encapsulating the collective emotions of all the characters.

Describing the film as a pure love story, Shrestha expressed his confidence in the new actors, stating, "I am confident that they will be welcomed by the film industry."

Kiran and Rakshya have undergone acting training and are set to make their debut with this project.

The film, produced in collaboration with Roman Films and Tapashree Films (Sikkim), includes artistes Anisha Rasaili, Shiv Shrestha, Wilson Bikram Rai, Sunita Shrestha, and others.

Rajaram Budhathoki serves as the producer while Komal Gurung is co-producer.

The story, screenplay, and dialogues of the movie are by Parichhed Sen and Purushottam Dhungel while Sankalpa Bhujel directed the cinematography.

The film showcases the picturesque landscapes of Sikkim and Nepal.

Notably, the movie features a revamped version of the popular song 'Kaalo Chasma Lau Hai Maiya' from the film 'Badalpari'.

The remake is penned by Surendra Rana and Shambhujit Baskota has composed the music. Pramod Kharel and Milan Newar have lent their voice to the song.

Greta Gerwig, Noah Baumbach marry after 12 yrs of dating

AGENCIES
New York, Dec. 20



After a terrific run at the global box-office with her directorial 'Barbie', Greta Gerwig has now turned a leaf on the new chapter in her life.

Greta and her longtime partner, Noah Baumbach are married, reports People magazine. A source said that the two got married in New York City Hall.

The couple first met while filming the 2010 movie 'Greenberg' and began their romantic relationship in 2011.

The news comes after a busy year for the couple who co-wrote the 'Barbie' screenplay and announced that they quietly welcomed a second son in an interview with Elle UK published in July.

"The little guy is sleeping through the night. But I'm still doing that thing where I wake up, every hour to 90 minutes, and just hover. You just keep wanting to look at that baby. So I'm slightly in a twilight state," the director told the outlet.

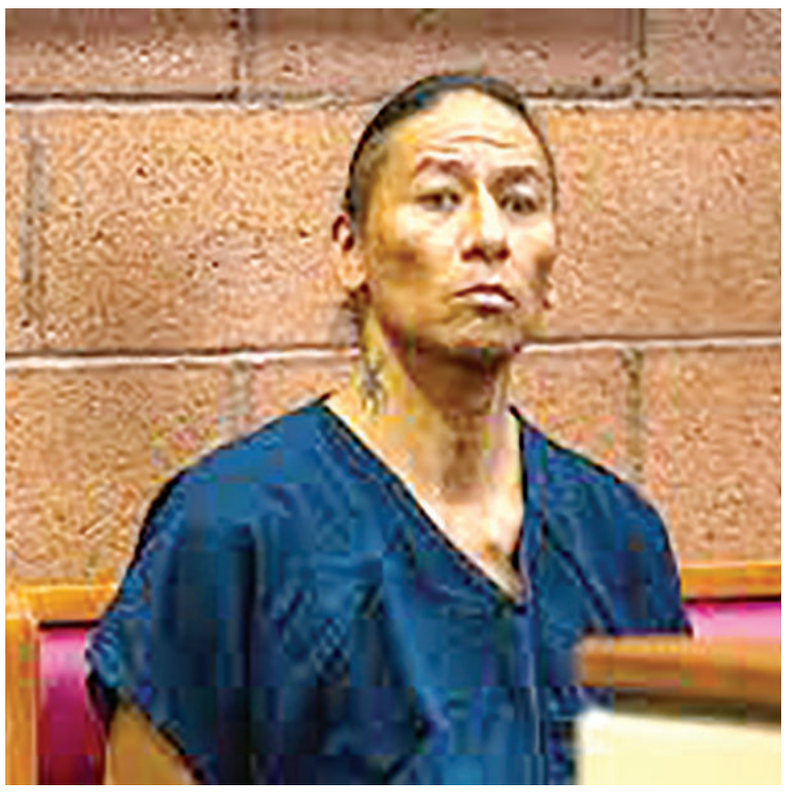
As per People, the new addition joined the couple's first baby together, son Harold Ralph Gerwig Baumbach, whom they welcomed in March 2019.

That December, Noah, 54, spoke to Vogue about why he enjoys working alongside his now wife.

"I think the pleasure of writing for us is that it seeps into everything. I'd show her a cut of my movie, and then a few months later, I'm watching her movie. I don't want to sound sickeningly happy, but it's a truly great thing to watch someone you love make something and love the thing they make. I don't know how else to say it without saying great a lot," he told the outlet. In 2020, the two had the honour of being nominated for Oscars in the same year.

Nevada high court upholds sex abuse charges against actor Nathan Chasing Horse

AP
Las Vegas, Dec. 20



The Nevada Supreme Court has denied Nathan Chasing Horse's request to toss a sprawling indictment that accuses the former "Dances With Wolves" actor of leading a cult, taking underage wives and sexually abusing Indigenous women and girls for decades.

The court's decision means prosecutors can proceed with their 18-count criminal case after months of delayed proceedings while Chasing Horse challenged it. The 47-year-old has been in custody since his arrest in January near the North Las Vegas home he is said to have shared with five wives.

Chasing Horse pleaded not guilty to the charges, which include sexual assault of a minor, kidnapping and child abuse. His lawyers argued that the case should be dismissed because, the former actor said, the sexual encounters were consensual. One of his accusers was younger than 16, the age of consent in Nevada, when the alleged abuse began, authorities said.

Public defender Kristy Holston also argued that the indictment was an overreach by the Clark County district attorney's office. She said some of the evidence presented to the grand jury, including a definition of grooming, had tainted the state's case.

Holston didn't immediately respond to a Tuesday request for comment on the state Supreme Court's decision.

Chasing Horse is known for his portrayal of Smiles a Lot in the 1990 film "Dances with Wolves."

Law enforcement authorities say in the decades since starring in the Oscar-winning movie, Chasing Horse built a name for himself among tribes as a self-proclaimed medicine man while traveling around North America to perform healing ceremonies. They say he used his position to gain access to vulnerable girls and women starting in the early 2000s.

The abuse allegations cross multiple U.S. states, including Nevada, where he was living at the time of his arrest, as well as Montana and South Dakota, according to the indictment.

One of the victims identified in the Nevada case was 14 when Chasing Horse told her that the spirits of their ancestors had instructed him to have sex with her, according to court documents and prosecutors.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: Power plays are the order of the day. Your attention is shifting sky high as the Sun enters your 10th House of Career, marking an exciting window of opportunity when you can make more progress and open more doors.

Taurus: It's your turn to get out and explore the world. Adventure is reeling you in as the Sun casts itself into your extensive 9th house. There's no way of knowing what you don't know until you encounter intriguing questions or magnetic opportunities.

Gemini: Without warning, your life may become a puzzling film noir. A distinct mystery is hanging over you as the Sun enters your secretive 8th house, setting your life up to feel like you've stepped into the pages of a Sherlock Holmes story.

Cancer: The perspective of others is immensely valuable at present. As the Sun enters your 7th House of Bonds, it brings your most important connections to the front of the line.

Leo: A little spring cleaning is in order, regardless of the season. The Sun is marching into your 6th House of Efficiency, a very task-oriented sector that is great for improving the general quality of your life by focusing on the smaller details of your routine.

Virgo: Let loose and live a little, Virgo! It's time to kick back as the Sun shimmies into your fun-loving 5th house for its annual visit, giving you cosmic permission to leave serious matters for another day.

Libra: The couch is calling your name. The Sun is settling down in your homey 4th house for the next month, so don't be shocked if you feel the urge to nest while you leave the rest of the world on pause.

Scorpio: What's happening outside your window, Scorpio? Your neighborhood is buzzing with fresh energy as the Sun arrives in your 3rd House of Nearby Community, encouraging you to interact more with people.

Sagittarius: A little budgetary circumspection is a good idea at the moment. You're entering the perfect time of year to get your finances in tip-top shape as the Sun bounds into your 2nd House of Income.

Capricorn: The cosmic green light is on, and it's your turn to go. The Sun is blasting into your 1st House of Self-Expression, announcing your cosmically mandated time of year to get in touch with your own goals and desires and ensure.

Aquarius: Yes, Aquarius, you're allowed to hit the snooze button a few extra times. There is a general easing up on the cosmic pressure as the Sun slips into your sleepy 12th house for the next month.

Pisces: This is no time to fly solo. There is an emphasis on coming together with like-minded souls as the Sun enters your 11th House of Friendship, making for an exciting and sociable time of the year.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



Jhapa end Dhangadhi's unbeaten run



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 20

Jhapa FC (JFC) revived its hopes for the playoffs at the Nepal Super League after ending the unbeaten run of Dhangadhi FC (DFC) with a 2-0 win at Nepal Super League on Wednesday.

Jhapa has now climbed to the fourth position with 10 points in seven matches. Dhangadhi, which had won three and tied three, has to wait for a confirmation to book its place in the playoffs after the defeat. Dhangadhi stands at the second position of the table with 12 points in seven matches.

Dhangadhi and Jhapa will be playing their final league matches against table-topper Pokhara Thunders FC, the team which has already qualified for the playoffs, and eighth-placed FC Chitwan on December 22 respectively.

The two goals of the match came in the second half. The first half ended goalless as both teams failed to convert several chances into goals.

JFC created a chance in the very first minute as Prashant Laksam stole the ball after the kickoff by DFC and passed the ball inside the box for Jorge Pelaez Sanchez, commonly known as Canillas. However, Canillas failed to chip the ball above Mohamad Taha, DFC's goalie. Canillas missed a similar chance in the 24th minute. Taha also blocked a powerful shot from Canillas in the 41st minute.

On the other hand, JFC's Stefan Cupic also had his hands full. DFC had five out of seven shots on target until the 36th minute. Striker Ahmad Hijazi among other DFC players tried to score but failed.

After DFC's pressure in the first half, the second half was also expected to be similar. Meanwhile, it was JFC that scored two and kept the chances for the playoffs alive. A cross by Chhiring Lama inside the box from the right flank was headed for the first goal by Anjan Bista, captain and marquee player for JFC, in the 53rd minute.

DFC coach Yougal Kishor Rai made three substitutions in the 65th minute and brought striker Afeez Olawale into the field with the expectation of making a comeback. However, it was again JFC that scored.

A pass by Pradip Lama, a substitute player, inside the box found Canillas in the 77th minute. Canillas pushed the ball towards the goal, but Samiraj Thokar, another substitute, got the final touch to the second goal of the match. Despite bringing Olawale, DFC failed to make a comeback. Moreover, DFC could not score even when JFC fell short of a man after Dhiraj Thakali was sent off with a red card in the 79th minute.

Anjan Bista was adjudged the player of the match. "We will come with a winning mentality in the final match to keep our chances for the playoffs alive," said Bista after receiving the award.

Title defender Kathmandu Rayzrs FC is competing against Birgunj United FC on Thursday. Kathmandu has to win the match against Birgunj, which is the bottom team in the league, to play in the playoffs as it dropped to the fifth position after Jhapa won against Dhangadhi.

NZ clinch series with comfortable victory



AP
Nelson, Dec. 20

Henry Nicholls made 95 and Will Young 89, trumping Soumya Sarkar's career-best 169 and leading New Zealand to a seven-wicket win over Bangladesh on Wednesday in the second one-day international.

New Zealand holds a winning 2-0 lead in the three-match series which ends Saturday in Napier.

Nicholls returned to form but fell just short of his second ODI century while Young narrowly missed his second straight ODI century as New Zealand made 296-3 in reply to Bangladesh's 291. Young made 105 as New Zealand won the rain-affected first match of the series by 44 runs.

Young put on 76 for the first wicket with Rachin Ravindra who made 45 from 33 balls after making a first-ball duck in the first match on Sunday.

Young then added 128, effectively in a match-winning partnership, for the second wicket with Nicholls who also bounced back after a second-ball duck in the opening ODI.

Tom Latham and Tom Blundell saw New Zealand home with 22 balls to spare, Blundell finishing the chase with a six in the 47th over.

Earlier, Sarkar made his 169 from 151 balls as it batted first after losing the toss.

Sarkar's score was the second-highest by a Bangladesh batsman in one-day internationals behind Litton Das's 174 against Zimbabwe and the second highest by a visiting batsman in a one-day international in New Zealand.

The left-hander had a reprieve on 92 when he offered a catching chance to Young at point which Young put down as the ball swirled in a steady breeze. Sarkar went on to reach his third one-day international century from 116 balls as the mainstay of the Bangladesh innings.

Bangladesh struggled to generate momentum early in its innings against tight bowling and also was impeded by losing its first four wickets for 80 runs in just over 20 overs.

SAfrica level series

Tony de Zorzi scored his maiden ODI hundred as South Africa beat India by eight wickets to level the three-match series on Tuesday.

De Zorzi scored 119 runs off 122 balls, including nine fours and six sixes, as South Africa finished with 215-2 in 42.3 overs.

That was after India was restricted to 211 runs in 46.2 overs with Sai Sudharsan and skipper Lokesh Rahul scoring half-centuries.

Left-arm pacers Nandre Burger and Bueran Hendricks shared five wickets for 64 runs in 19.2 overs. Left-arm spinner Keshav Maharaj finished with 2-51.

Earlier, put into bat, India had trouble contending with the seaming conditions on offer. Unlike with South Africa in Johannesburg, its batting didn't completely fold.

Sudharsan, playing his second ODI, scored a consecutive half-century and added 68 off 91 balls with Rahul for the third wicket.

Lizaad Williams got the breakthrough with Sudharsan out caught in the 27th over. His dismissal opened the floodgates for India, as it lost the last eight wickets for 97 runs.

Rahul was out caught for 56 off 64 balls. Burger finished with 3-30 in 10 overs, while Hendricks took 2-34.

PHOTO: AFP
New Zealand's Henry Nicholls plays a shot during the second ODI cricket match against Bangladesh in Nelson.

England beat WIndies

World champion England set up a Twenty20 series-deciding match with the West Indies after crushing the fourth game by 75 runs on Tuesday.

A second consecutive century by opener Phil Salt from a flying start with captain Jos Buttler set up England's highest T20 score of 267-3.

The West Indies stayed with the run rate required but couldn't stop leaking wickets and was all out for 192 in the 16th over.

Salt and Buttler racked up 117 runs in 9.5 overs. Buttler was caught on the boundary for a 29-ball 55.

Salt was on 61 and accelerated even more, reaching a 48-ball hundred, and becoming the first Englishman to score two T20 centuries.

He was out for 119, the highest T20 score by an Englishman, when he was bowled by an Andre Russell yorker. Salt's second ton in three days featured 10 sixes and seven boundaries.

But England was still shredding the West Indies bowlers; Will Jacks made 24 off nine deliveries and Liam Livingstone blasted an unbeaten 54 off 21, including four sixes and four boundaries.

Their 267-3 was the fifth highest score in men's T20 history.

SNIPPETS

PM Cup from today

Kathmandu (TRN): The Prime Minister Cup Women's T20 National Cricket tournament is set to begin in Kathmandu on Thursday. The tournament, which will run until January 2, will be held at TU and Mulpani Cricket Ground. For the first time, a total of eight teams, including seven provincial teams and APF Club, will participate in the round-robin league domestic tournament for women. Rubina Chhetri, the captain of Koshi Province and a former national captain, expressed her gratitude to the Cricket Association of Nepal (CAN) for organizing the league-based tournament. All the other team captains also expressed their appreciation and believed that the tournament would enhance the players' performance. On the first day, TU will host Bagmati versus Madhesh and Gandaki versus Lumbini, while Mulpani will host APF versus Sudurpaschim and Karnali versus Koshi.

South Asian Skateboard today

Kathmandu (TRN): The South Asia Skateboard Championship and 5th Skate Jatra's second edition is scheduled to start on Thursday in Butwal. Acyut Khanal, the president of Nepal Skateboard and Skateboarding Association, has confirmed that Nepal, India, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Bhutan, Pakistan, Maldives, Myanmar, and Thailand will compete in the event. Around 100 Nepali skateboarders will showcase their skateboarding skills, while 40 participants from each of the other countries will fight for the title of USD 1000 in both men's and women's categories. On Thursday, sixteen players from each country will advance to the semi-final stage after the qualifiers. Eight players from each country will then progress to the final round.

Praful, Prince advance

Kathmandu (TRN): Praful Maharjan and Prince Dahal entered the pre-quarterfinals of the 2nd Lalitpur Mayor's Cup National Badminton Tournament on Wednesday. In the men's singles, the winner of the 3rd Prime Minister's Cup, Praful of the Tribhuvan Army Club (TAC) defeated Abhik Shrestha of the Nepal Police Club (NPC) 21-5, 21-10. Similarly, Prince representing APF Club defeated Shishir Rana of Kailali in straight sets 21-9, 21-6. Likewise, Bishnu Katuwal (NPC), Kshitij Khanal (APF), Abhay Maharjan (TAC), Aman Maharjan (APF), Devraj Rana (AFP), Arun Adhikari (AFP), Sujan Thapa (APF), Suvin Shrestha (TAC) and Roshan Saud (APF) advanced.

Chelsea, Fulham reach League Cup semifinals

AP
London, Dec. 20



Chelsea's faltering first season under Mauricio Pochettino could yet be saved by the English League Cup.

The London club reached the semifinals by beating Newcastle 4-2 in a penalty shootout on Tuesday, with the game only getting that far thanks to a goal by Chelsea winger Mykhailo Mudryk in the second minute of stoppage time that made it 1-1 at Stamford Bridge.

Newcastle right back Kieran Trippier was at fault for that goal and he was one of two visiting players to fail to score his penalty. Matt Ritchie was the other, as stand-in goalkeeper Đor□e Petrovi□ made the save to end the shootout.

Newcastle had been looking to get to the semifinals of the League Cup for the second straight season. Fulham has reached that stage for the first time in its 144-year history.

Fulham, another team from west London, also needed a penalty shootout to advance and this one lasted longer, with defender Tosin Adarabioyo eventually netting the clinching kick for a 7-6 win. Amadou Onana had a chance to win the shootout for Everton but had his attempt saved at 4-3.

The game finished 1-1 in regulation at Goodison Park, with Everton substitute Beto scoring in the 82nd to cancel out an own-goal by Michael Keane.

Griezmann ties Aragonés

Atletico Madrid failed to make history of its own on a night Antoine Griezmann tied Luis Aragonés as the club's all-time top scorer.

Griezmann scored twice on Tuesday to tie Aragonés on 173 goals, but Atletico conceded a stoppage-time equalizer in a 3-3 draw with Getafe that ended the club's record-tying 20-game home winning streak.

Griezmann scored his 172nd goal with Atletico in the 44th minute and then tied Aragonés' record by converting a 69th-minute penalty kick. Aragonés reached his mark in 370 matches, while Griezmann needed 364 games with the club.

The draw lifted Atletico to third place in the league standings after 17 matches.

Napoli stunned

Frosinone's best cup run continued as it stunned defending Serie A champion Napoli by winning 4-0 at the Stadio Diego Armando Maradona on Tuesday to reach the Italian Cup quarterfinals. Frosinone will play its quarterfinal on Jan. 10. Juventus hosts Salernitana on Jan. 4.

Man City ease to Club World Cup final

AP
Jeddah, Dec. 20



Manchester City set aside struggles at home to ease past Urawa Red Diamonds 3-0 in the Club World Cup semifinals on Tuesday and is one game away from a fifth title in 2023.

The champion of Europe has never lost to the champion of Asia at a Club World Cup and it never looked likely on a balmy evening in the Red Sea port city Jeddah.

After it took Man City until first-half stoppage time to score from an own goal by defender Marius Hoibraten, Mateo Kova□i□ and Bernardo Silva struck with shots in a seven-minute spell early in the second half against the Japanese team. Man City now will be favored to beat Fluminense of Brazil in the final on Friday.

"It's the only title that the club don't have," City manager Pep Guardiola said. "The players know how important this game is for all of us at the club."

Guardiola's team keeps finding respite in international games during an untypical run in the Premier League where the defending champion has won just one of its last six games while leaking late goals.

A winning Club World Cup debut followed City closing out a perfect six-win streak in its Champions League group this month. City also added a UEFA Super Cup title in August to its storied trophy treble last season of Champions League, Premier League and English FA Cup.

City needed some help to score first Friday when Hoibraten diverted goalward a pass across the goalmouth by Matheus Nunes that was unlikely to find another of the six midfield players in the starting lineup. With Erling Haaland still ruled out by a foot injury, Guardiola also opted to leave Argentina forward Julián Álvarez on the bench.

In the 52nd, deep-lying midfielder Kova□i□ exploited the space left vacant where Haaland would be to surge forward and shoot after collecting Kyle Walker's long pass.

It was shooting practice for City seven minutes later when Bernardo Silva scored with the help of a slight deflection after goalkeeper Shusaku Nishikawa pushed away Nunes' first effort.

City cruised through the last half-hour and Guardiola detailed an approach in Jeddah for his squad that is on a constant two-games-per-week program this season.

"The plan is to sleep and to sleep and to sleep," the coach said, praising Walker as an "incredible captain" who organizes social time for teammates. Urawa coach Maciej Skor□a acknowledged his players could not handle the Premier League champion's "huge offensive power. They know what the gap is."

WEATHER

Thursday

Sunrise at 6:50 am, Sunset at 5:13 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Thursday)

Partly cloudy to mainly fair throughout the country.

Expected Temp.: 17-19 Rain Probability: 0%

Wednesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	15.7	2.7	0.0
Dipayal	22.0	3.5	0.0
Dhangadi	24.1	8.4	0.0
Birendranagar	20.0	5.8	0.0
Nepalgunj	24.0	9.0	0.0
Jumla	20.9	-4.7	0.0
Ghorahi	22.0	8.2	0.0
Pokhara	21.8	8.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	24.4	8.2	0.0
Simara	25.3	9.4	0.0
Kathmandu	17.9	5.0	0.0
Okhaldhunga	18.6	5.7	0.0
Taplejung	17.6	6.0	0.0
Dhankuta	23.0	9.0	0.0
Biratnagar	27.0	10.0	0.0
Jomsom	15.0	-4.0	0.0*
Dharan	26.5	13.4	0.0*
Lumle	16.0	4.5	0.0*
Janakpur	28.6	9.6	0.0*
Jiri	17.3	-1.2	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

December 21, 2023

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.78	Rs. 133.38
Euro	1	Rs. 145.27	Rs. 145.93
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.03	Rs. 168.79
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 153.91	Rs. 154.61
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 89.84	Rs. 90.24
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 99.57	Rs. 100.02
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.82	Rs.100.27
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.26	Rs. 9.30
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.59	Rs. 18.68
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.39	Rs. 35.55
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.43	Rs. 36.60
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.80	Rs. 3.81
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.15	Rs. 36.32
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.51	Rs. 28.63
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.20	Rs. 10.25
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.06	Rs. 13.12
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.48	Rs. 19.57
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 17.01	Rs. 17.09
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.52	Rs. 433.47
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.19	Rs. 353.78

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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